

Dozens killed in cartel attacks in Mexico

President Sheinbaum seeks to quell fears about violence after drug kingpin's slaying.

By KATE LINTHICUM, PATRICK J. McDONNELL AND CECILIA SÁNCHEZ VIDAL

MEXICO CITY — A top-secret special forces operation that killed the world's most wanted drug trafficker Sunday was meant to highlight the Mexican government's prowess in combating crime.

But retaliatory violence by angry cartel members who torched cars, killed dozens of soldiers and spread mayhem in 20 of Mexico's 32 states instead sparked widespread fear about the vast reach of organized crime here — and the government's ability to tame it.

Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum sought to quell fears Monday after violence erupted over the killing of a long-elusive cartel kingpin: Nemesio Rubén Oseguera Cervantes, known as “El Mencho.”

“The country is at peace,” Sheinbaum told reporters at her daily news conference in Mexico City on Monday. “It's calm.”

“Mexico has solid institu- [See Attacks, A4]

Hunkering down in a resort town

Californians lie low in Puerto Vallarta after violence erupts across Mexico. **WORLD, A3**

Cartel boss ‘El Mencho’ had an early arrest in S.F.

By KEEGAN HAMILTON

Long before he had a \$15-million bounty on his head as the leader of Mexico's ruthless Jalisco New Generation cartel, Nemesio Rubén Oseguera Cervantes was a scruffy-haired kid trying to eke out a living on the streets of San Francisco.

He crossed the border illegally sometime before he turned 20, making the migrant's journey north from the avocado and lime orchards that surround his family's small town in the state of Michoacán. He was picked up first on meth charges on May 14, 1986, according to news reports and a San Francisco police booking photo, which shows him in a blue hoodie scowling into the camera. He was arrested twice more, finally for selling \$9,500 worth of heroin to two undercover officers at a bar in 1992.

He went to prison, was deported and, despite his record, became a local police officer back home.

So began the criminal career of one of the most infamous figures in the world of international drug trafficking. It ended in spectacular and violent fashion Sunday, with Mexican authorities announcing that the kingpin nicknamed “El Mencho” had been killed in a shootout with government forces in Jalisco, the state his group, known as the CJNG, has long dominated. He was believed to be 59.

The killing unleashed shock waves of violence across the swaths of Mexico where the CJNG holds sway. Flights into some Jalisco air- [See ‘El Mencho,’ A4]



A CHARRED BUS in Guadalajara, top, the day after the slaying of the cartel leader known as “El Mencho.” Above, soldiers clear a road leading to Tapalpa.

Trans athletes resisting efforts to sideline them

California teens at the center of a national debate

By Kevin Rector

At a recent meeting of California's high school sports governing board, two seniors from Arroyo Grande High School spoke out against a transgender peer competing on their track and field team and allegedly “watching” them in the girls' locker room.

One of the Central Coast students said she is “more comfortable” changing in her car now. The other cited a Bible verse about God creating men and women separately, and accused the California Interscholastic Federation of subjecting girls to “exploitative and intrusive behavior that is disguised through transgender ideology.”

“Our privacy is being compromised and our sports are being taken over,” she said.

During the same meeting, Trevor Norcross, the father of 17-year-old transgen-

Paramount makes new Warner bid, putting spotlight on politics

By MEG JAMES

As Paramount moved Monday to sweeten its bid for Warner Bros. Discovery, a high-stakes political battle is playing out behind the scenes.

Paramount's latest offer enhanced its earlier \$30-a-share bid, valued at \$108 billion, said a person familiar with the process who was not authorized to comment publicly. Details of the revised proposal, first reported by Bloomberg, were not immediately available.

The firm is leveraging both the dynastic wealth of

Bomb cyclone slams Northeast

It's the strongest storm in a decade, dumping over 2 feet of snow and forcing millions to stay home. **NATION, A5**

Kaiser workers' walkout ends

Union representing thousands of staffers cites a breakthrough in contract talks. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Reiners' son pleads not guilty

Nick Reiner is arraigned in Los Angeles in the slayings of Rob and Michele Reiner. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Buyer emerges for L.A. plaza

A Riverside County developer seeks to finish the stalled \$1.2-billion project. **BUSINESS, A9**



OCEANWIDE PLAZA has been plagued by vandals.

Trump facing a slew of crises before address

President's annual speech to Congress comes amid growing political turmoil.

By ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — President Trump will deliver his annual State of the Union address Tuesday night at a moment of unusual upheaval, confronting a cascade of crises that have left Washington unsettled and his own political standing diminished early in his second term.

When lawmakers gather to hear the president's agenda for the year ahead, the scene is expected to reflect an undeterred president under increasing political strain.

The president is facing a partial government shutdown triggered by his administration's aggressive deportation campaign, rising tensions over the United States' involvement in foreign conflicts and growing domestic dissent that is fracturing the president's political alliances and aggravating his rivals.

Adding to the turbulent atmosphere is the economic unease in an election year. The president, who a year ago promised to bring down prices for consumers, in-

sisted Monday that America has “the greatest economy we've ever had” even though public polling shows economic pressures are worrying a majority of Americans.

Trump said he plans to talk about the country's economic successes in his speech, saying “it is going to be a long speech because we have so much to talk about.”

Republicans have recently pushed Trump to focus on efforts to lower costs, a message they see as crucial to help them keep control of Congress. What remains to be seen is how much of Trump's economic message will be colored by a Supreme Court decision last week that struck down his use of tariffs, a key portion of his economic agenda. In recent days, the president has remained defiant on the issue, lashing out at the justices for delivering a legal setback on his tariffs, and looking to impose new global tariffs in a different way.

Trump said Monday he does not need to seek congressional approval to impose new levies, even though the nation's highest court ruled his tariffs cannot stand without the approval of Congress.

“As president, I do not have to go back to Congress to get approval of Tariffs,” Trump wrote on Truth Social. “It has already been got- [See Speech, A7]



TEYANA Gibson Brown is welcomed by Sen. Richard Blumenthal, left, as she prepares to testify Monday.

Filings reveal deep cuts in ICE training

Recruits get nearly 250 fewer hours of instruction than prior cohorts, memo says.

By ANDREA CASTILLO

WASHINGTON — New whistleblower documents detail substantial cuts by the Trump administration to the training requirements for new immigration officers.

Among the cuts are the elimination of practical exams, use-of-force and legal training courses, and an overall reduction in training time, contrary to an official's testimony to Congress earlier this month.

The documents, provided to Sen. Richard Blumenthal (D-Conn.) by whistleblowers from the Department of Homeland Security, were publicly revealed ahead of a forum Monday with congressional

Democrats — the third in recent weeks probing what the members view as abusive and illegal tactics used by federal agents.

Lauren Bis, deputy assistant public affairs secretary at Homeland Security, said no training hours have been cut.

“Our officers receive extensive firearm training, are taught de-escalation tactics, and receive 4th and 5th Amendment comprehensive instruction,” she said. “The training does not stop after graduation from the academy. Recruits are put on a rigorous on-the-job training program that is tracked and monitored.”

Earlier this month, acting ICE Director Todd Lyons testified to Congress that while the agency had reduced the number of training days to 42 from 75, “we went from five days a week to six days a week. Five days a week was five eight-hour days and we've gone to six 12- [See Whistleblower, A6]

Weather
Sunshine and warmth.
L.A. Basin: 78/54. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**
Obituaries **B5**
Learning **A8**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.

7 85944 00200 5